

Option B4: Early Elizabethan England, 1558–88

Key topic 1: Queen, government and religion, 1558–69

1 The situation on Elizabeth's accession	- Elizabethan England in 1558: society and government. - The Virgin Queen: the problem of her legitimacy, gender, marriage. Her character and strengths. - Challenges at home and from abroad: financial weaknesses, religious divisions, the French threat.
2 The 'settlement' of religion	- Elizabeth's religious settlement (1559): its features and impact. - The Church of England: its role in society.
3 Challenge to the religious settlement	- The nature and extent of the Puritan challenge. - The nature and extent of the Catholic challenge, including the role of the nobility, Papacy and foreign powers.
4 The problem of Mary, Queen of Scots	- Mary, Queen of Scots: her claim to the English throne. - Relations between Elizabeth and Mary, 1568–69.

Key topic 2: Challenges to Elizabeth at home and abroad, 1569–88

1 Plots and revolts at home	- The reasons for, and significance of, the Revolt of the Northern Earls, 1569–70. - The features and significance of the Ridolfi, Throckmorton and Babington plots. Walsingham and the use of spies. - The reasons for, and significance of, Mary Queen of Scots' execution in 1587.
2 Relations with Spain	- Political, religious and commercial rivalry. - The significance of privateering and the activities of Drake.
3 Outbreak of war with Spain, 1585–88	- Reasons for deteriorating relations with Spain: English direct involvement in the Netherlands and the actions of Robert Dudley. - Drake and the raid on Cadiz: 'Singeing the King of Spain's beard'.
4 The Armada	- Spanish invasion plans. Key events of the Spanish Armada. - The reasons for the English victory.

Key topic 3: Elizabethan society in the Age of Exploration, 1558–88

1 Education and leisure	• Education in the home and schools. • Sport, pastimes and the theatre.
2 The 'problem' of the poor	• The reasons for the increase in poverty and vagabondage during these years. • The changing attitudes and policies towards the poor.
3 Exploration and voyages of discovery	• Factors prompting exploration, including the impact of new technology on ships and sailing and the drive to expand trade. • The reasons for, and significance of, Drake's circumnavigation of the globe.
4 Attempted colonisation of Virginia	• Reasons for the attempted colonisation of Virginia, including the significance of Raleigh. • Reasons for the failure of the first settlement in Virginia.